Retirement Plan Access and Participation Among Private-Sector Workers, 2010–2024

Alejandro De La Torre

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1 Introduction

This exercise constructs annual measures of retirement plan *access* and *participation* among private-sector wage-and-salary workers ages 20–64 from 2010 through 2024 using the Current Population Survey Annual Social and Economic Supplement (CPS ASEC). Access refers to whether a worker's employer offers a retirement plan, while participation refers to whether the worker is included in such a plan.

Using harmonized IPUMS-CPS microdata, I construct a consistent analytic sample of private-sector workers and estimate weighted annual rates of retirement plan access and participation. The goal of the exercise is descriptive rather than causal: to produce transparent and replicable measures of retirement plan coverage over time while clearly documenting the sample construction, survey questions used to define the measures, and important issues of interpretation—particularly the CPS ASEC questionnaire redesign introduced in the mid-2010s.

2 Data and Sample Construction

The analysis uses pooled person-level microdata from the IPUMS harmonized version of the Current Population Survey Annual Social and Economic Supplement (CPS ASEC) for survey years 2010 through 2024. The assignment asks for annual measures of retirement plan access and participation among private-sector workers ages 20–64, so the starting point is the full pooled ASEC extract and the analytic sample is narrowed to the subset of respondents relevant to that population. The extract includes the key labor-force, class-of-worker, and retirement-plan variables needed for the exercise, along with the ASEC person weight used to produce nationally representative estimates.

I construct the analytic sample in four steps. First, I retain only survey years 2010–2024. Second, I restrict the sample to working-age adults ages 20–64. Third, I keep only respondents who are employed at the time of the survey using the CPS employment-status variable `EMPSTAT`. Workers coded as `EMPSTAT = 10` ("at work") or `EMPSTAT = 12` ("has job, not at work last week") are included. The goal of the exercise is to measure access to employer-sponsored retirement plans among current workers, so unemployed respondents, retirees, and individuals out of the labor force are excluded from the denominator.

Fourth, among employed respondents I retain only private-sector wage-and-salary workers using the CPS class-of-worker variable `CLASSWKR`. In the IPUMS coding scheme, private wage-and-salary workers correspond to code 21. Government employees, members of the armed forces, unpaid family workers, and the self-employed are excluded. This restriction is important conceptually: the measures used in this exercise are framed around whether an employer offers a retirement plan

and whether a worker is included in that plan, so wage-and-salary employment provides the most consistent denominator for an employer-sponsored coverage measure.

After applying these restrictions, the analytic sample consists of private-sector wage-and-salary workers ages 20–64 observed in the CPS ASEC from 2010 through 2024. The resulting pooled dataset contains over eight hundred thousand person-year observations, with annual unweighted sample sizes generally ranging from roughly 45,000 to 63,000 respondents depending on the year. Because the CPS ASEC is a repeated cross-section rather than a panel used for longitudinal analysis, each year is treated as an independent nationally representative cross section and the pooled file is used only to construct comparable annual estimates.

All reported estimates are weighted using the CPS ASEC person weight `ASECWT`. Applying this weight ensures that the annual estimates represent the population of private-sector wage-and-salary workers in the United States rather than the raw survey sample alone. The use of person weights is standard practice when constructing descriptive statistics from CPS ASEC microdata.

Finally, one design feature of the CPS ASEC is relevant for interpreting the resulting time series. Beginning with the 2014 survey, the Census Bureau introduced a redesigned income questionnaire for a portion of the sample in order to improve the reporting of income sources, including retirement-related income. Because retirement-plan questions are conceptually related to these broader retirement-income measures, changes around the mid-2010s should be interpreted cautiously. Any sharp movements in the series between the pre- and post-redesign periods may reflect both genuine changes in retirement-plan coverage and improvements in measurement resulting from the updated questionnaire structure.

3 Measuring Retirement Plan Access and Participation

Retirement plan access and participation are measured using the CPS ASEC retirement coverage questions harmonized in the IPUMS-CPS dataset. Access captures whether a worker's employer offers a pension or retirement plan, while participation captures whether the worker is included in such a plan.

In the CPS ASEC, respondents who are employed are asked whether their employer offers a pension or retirement plan for any of its employees. Workers who report that their employer offers a plan are classified as having retirement plan *access*. Respondents are then asked whether they are included in the employer's plan. Workers who report that they are included are classified as *participants*.

Formally, the access rate is defined as the share of workers in the analytic sample who report that their employer offers a retirement plan. The participation rate is defined as the share of workers who report that they are included in such a plan. Both measures are computed annually using the CPS ASEC person weights so that estimates represent the population of private-sector wage-and-salary workers in the United States.

4 Estimation Approach

Annual estimates of retirement plan access and participation are computed using weighted descriptive statistics. For each survey year, the access rate is calculated as the weighted share of workers in the analytic sample who report that their employer offers a retirement plan. The participation rate is calculated as the weighted share of workers who report that they are included in a retirement plan.

All estimates use the CPS ASEC person weight `ASECWT`. This weight adjusts for the CPS sampling design and ensures that the resulting estimates are representative of the national population of private-sector wage-and-salary workers ages 20–64. Applying the person weight is standard practice when producing descriptive statistics from CPS ASEC microdata.

Observations with missing or ambiguous responses to the retirement-plan questions are excluded from the numerator and denominator when constructing the measures. This approach ensures that the resulting estimates reflect only respondents with clearly interpretable answers to the relevant survey questions.

5 CPS ASEC Redesign in 2015

The interpretation of the resulting time series requires attention to changes in the CPS ASEC questionnaire. Beginning with the 2014 survey year, the Census Bureau introduced a redesigned income questionnaire for part of the sample, and beginning in 2015 the redesigned questionnaire was implemented for the full ASEC sample.

The redesign was intended to improve the reporting of income sources and retirement-related information. Because the measurement of retirement-plan coverage is conceptually linked to these broader income questions, the redesign may affect the comparability of responses before and after the change.

As a result, shifts in the estimated access and participation rates around the mid-2010s should be interpreted cautiously. Some portion of the observed change may reflect improvements in measurement rather than genuine changes in retirement-plan coverage among workers.

6 Results

The resulting estimates show that both retirement plan access and participation declined over the period from 2010 through 2024 among private-sector wage-and-salary workers ages 20–64. Access rates fell from slightly above one-half of workers at the beginning of the period to roughly two-fifths by the end of the sample, while participation rates followed a similar downward pattern. The gap between access and participation remains substantial throughout the period, indicating that a meaningful share of workers who have access to a retirement plan are not enrolled. The figure below summarizes the annual trends in access and participation rates.

Table 1: Retirement Plan Access Rates by Year

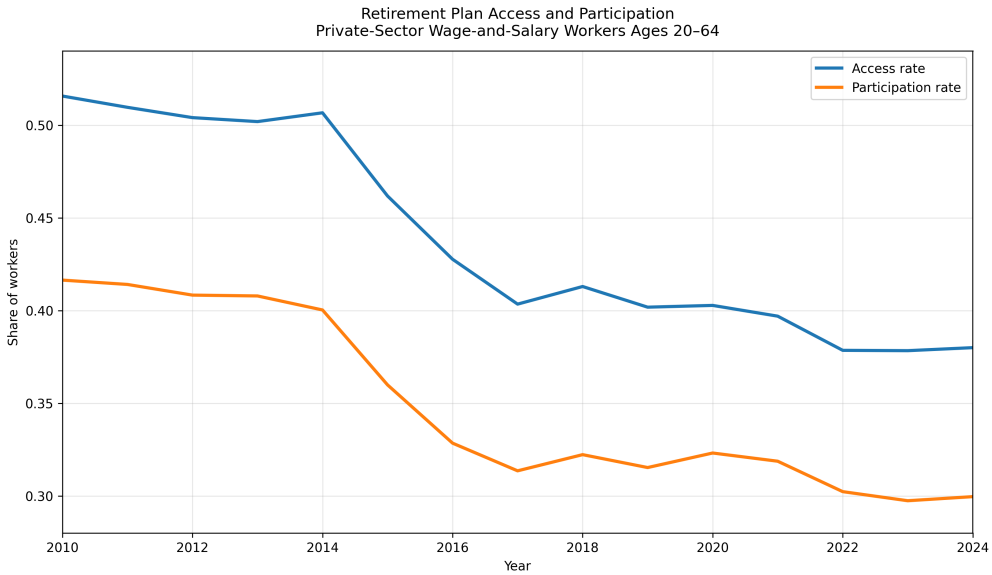

Figure 1: Retirement Plan Access and Participation Among Private-Sector Workers Ages 20–64